



The Confederate battery at Fort Moultrie firing on Fort Sumter in Charleston harbor on April 12, 1861. The attack triggered the Civil War, which devastated the US.

THE SPLIT IN THE US DEMOCRATIC PARTY ahead of the 1860 election precipitated a much larger, more dangerous fracture that came in 1861—the **secession** of Southern states to a confederacy. Many northerners, President Lincoln included, initially thought that slavery might just die out if it were not allowed in any new territories. But a gradual approach was not possible, since abolitionism kept growing, with more of the public supporting it over the 1850s.

The US was economically divided, which intensified the debate over slavery. The South was mostly rural, and slave labor was used to grow cotton, tobacco, and rice. The more urban Northern states, in contrast, had a high population of immigrant workers.

Lincoln's presidential victory was the last straw for Southern slave owners, and by December 1860 South Carolina had seceded from the Union. Over the next few



Union cap
Forage cap, with regiment badge, as worn by northern Union soldiers during the Civil War. Confederate soldiers wore the color gray.

months, it was followed by Georgia, Alabama, Louisiana, Mississippi, Texas, and Florida. These states formed the **Confederacy** and elected Jefferson Davis (1808–89) as their president. They were soon joined by Virginia, Arkansas, Tennessee, and North Carolina in the spring, although the slave-holding states of Kentucky, Missouri, Maryland, and Delaware did not secede. One of the underlying causes of secession, besides slavery, was the issue of the **states' rights** versus that of **federal** government. South Carolina and the other Confederate states argued that states held the right to own slaves and to leave the Union.

The situation grew increasingly tense. The continued presence of Union forces at **Fort Sumter**, in the harbor of Charleston, South Carolina, made many people there feel that their new sovereignty

was being compromised. So, at 4:30 a.m. on April 12, Brigadier-General P. G. T. Beauregard gave the order to fire on the soldiers stationed there. These would be the **opening shots** of the **American Civil War**.

Meanwhile, the second Italian War of Independence, which began in 1859 and was part of the wider struggle for unification of the **Italian states**, was coming to a close. France and Piedmont-Sardinia had formed an alliance to drive out Austrian rule in Italy, which they achieved through a series of victories in 1859. But during negotiations of the **Peace of Zurich**, Napoleon III of France allowed Austria to retain Venetia (mostly Venice), causing uproar among supporters of Italian independence. In the south, **Giuseppe Garibaldi** (1807–82), an Italian military commander, attacked the Kingdom of Two



Alexander II
Alexander was the emperor of Russia from 1855–81. He freed the serfs and reformed the judicial and education systems.

SOUTHERN CONFEDERACY

The Southern Confederacy equated to a new nation, and as such, needed a flag. The national flag of the Confederacy, known as the "Stars and Bars," closely resembled the northern states' Union flag. To avoid confusion on the battlefield, a new battle flag (right) was adopted, first by the Army of Northern Virginia, and later, by all Southern forces.

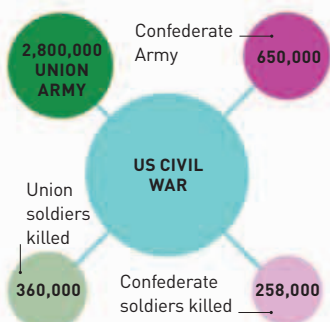


Sicilies, seizing Palermo in 1860. With most of the Italian kingdoms in a degree of upheaval, **Victor Emmanuel II** (1820–78) of Piedmont-Sardinia was declared "king of Italy." The struggle was not yet over, however, as France occupied Rome while Venice was under Austrian rule. Garibaldi's attempt to liberate the Papal States (Rome) in 1862 at the Battle of Aspromonte on August 29 ended in defeat, leaving the project of unification still incomplete.

In Russia, **serfdom** was abolished in wide-reaching changes by Russian emperor **Alexander II** (1818–81) who, after defeat in the Crimean War (see 1854), wanted to reform the country, starting with labor. He set out the **Edict of Emancipation** in 1861, despite opposition from landowners. Earlier attempts to abolish serfdom had been made around 1818, but with little success. Some 10 million people were freed on February 19 and were promised their own land.

“IT IS BETTER TO ABOLISH SERFDOM FROM ABOVE THAN TO WAIT FOR IT TO ABOLISH ITSELF FROM BELOW.”

Czar Alexander II of Russia



Costly civil war

The conflict between the North's federal government and 11 Southern states was brutal and bloody with a high rate of casualties and deaths.

